

Assertive Communication & I-Statements

Greater Nashua Mental Health Center

Instructions: Assertive communication expresses your needs and feelings honestly while respecting others — the middle ground between passive (silencing yourself) and aggressive (steamrolling others). 'I-statements' are its core tool.

Communication styles

- Passive: avoid, give in, hint — needs go unmet, resentment builds.
- Aggressive: blame, demand, attack — others get hurt, relationships strain.
- Assertive: clear, calm, respectful — 'I feel ___ when ___ because ___. I'd like ___.'

Build an I-statement

Situation:

I feel... (name the emotion)

...when... (describe the behavior/facts, not the person)

...because... (the effect on me)

I'd like / I would appreciate... (a clear, specific request)

Practice

Rewrite a recent passive or aggressive moment as an assertive I-statement: